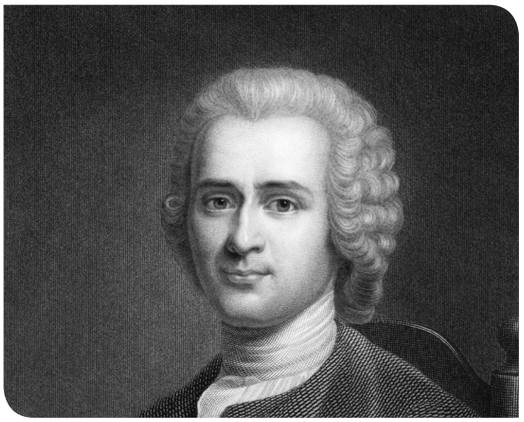
7.7 Jean-Jacques Rousseau (1712-1778)



Learning Objectives

- To understand the Political thought of ***Jean-Jacques Rousseau***
- To know about ***Jean-Jacques Rousseau***'s views on Human Nature, Theory of General Will, Sovereignty and Social Contract Theory.

Life and Times

Jean-Jacques Rousseau, one of the most prominent philosophers in the modern political discourse, was born on 28 July, 1712 in Geneva. Hailing from a broken family, ***Rousseau*** was devoid of the opportunity to enjoy the privilege of a nurtured childhood. After disengaging from a couple of apprenticeships, he fled from Geneva and found joy in wanderlust. With the help a young widow named ***Madame de Warens, Rousseau*** was introduced to formal education in a monastery based in Turin and a seminary in Annecy. The eventual aversion towards the style of pedagogy in those institutions, induced him to abandon the same. Out of the repeated failures, she was forced to send him to Lyons in 1730. After a year of wandering, he re-joined her in 1731 and lived under her bounty till 1740. Influenced by her intellectual halo and her invaluable assistance, he joined as a teacher in the family of Monsieur de Malby. Nonetheless, he left the assignment and resorted to his journey as an aimless soul.

His second trip to France in 1744 brought significant changes in his life. Despite his unsuccessful experiments in various fields like opera, theatre, poetry and so forth, ***Rousseau*** sustained his determination and positive spirit. The year 1749 was a turning point in his life. The Academy of Dijon announced the prize for the best essay on "Has the progress of sciences and arts contributed to corrupt or purify morals?" ***Rousseau*** writes in his Confessions, "Instantly I saw another universe, and I became another man". The work he submitted had received the first prize in 1750 and it was published under the title – "A Discourse on the Moral Effects of the Arts and Sciences".

On his return to Geneva in 1754, ***Rousseau***, a Catholic by himself, accepted Calvinistic denomination and reacquired the citizenship. After his travel to Paris, he spent 8 years of his life at Montmorency as a ward of Madame d'Epinay. ***Rousseau*** composed his most important works - The New Heloise (1761), Emile (1762) and the Social Contract (1762) – during this phase. Condemnation was the response received for his books which led to his further resettlements in various places. ***Rousseau***'s demise on 2 July, 1778, was received with a shock and was seen as a great loss to philosophy.

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